lined with soap and everything else you use. Basically, it is a wet bath, you wipe yourself. For shaving, you use gel and a razor. Everything is light, so it is very effortless moving things around.

Q. I don't know if you get asked this, but is it difficult to use the toilet in space?
Actually, this is the most-asked question, especially when I talk to kids. It is important because it is one of the most complicated or complex engineering solutions provided to compensate for the absence of gravity. The systems are designed to ensure there is always suction, with failsafe mechanisms. It is challenging and I would say your aim needs to be good. But, after the initial few days, you get used to it and learn quickly.

Q. Did you feel confined or claustrophobic on ISS?
No, it is big, equivalent to a 6BHK house. On the ground, you sit only on the sofa and walk on the floor. Though a room is 3D, we use only 2D. However, in space, you could be sitting on the ceiling and talking because you fully utilise all three dimensions. Essentially, the ISS is an orbiting laboratory. You are performing experiments and conducting research. So, there is a lot of equipment on the station and something is always on or moving. There is also a persistent ambient noise, but it is not very high and it becomes your new normal after a few days.

Q. What was your typical workday like in the three weeks that you were on the ISS?
The purpose of my mission, first of all, was to gain experience for our own human space mission, the Gaganyaan, which ISRO is pursuing and which is what we were selected for initially. In addition, we wanted to enable an ecosystem for conducting microgravity research in space. So, ISRO asked Indian institutions to select different research experiments, and I took seven of these with me and performed them on the station. These experiments would be slotted every day and I would carry them out, preserve the samples and bring them back to Earth for Indian scientists to examine. These have already been handed over to the researchers, and the results are likely to come out soon.

Q. Do describe some of these experiments.
The processes we have on Earth evolve in a certain way because of gravity. That changes in space, because of the absence of gravity. For instance, our muscles do not get exercised as much in space because there is no load on them and they degenerate. The stem cell experiment I was doing was looking into this aspect. Can we use any supplement to prevent this degeneration and enhance the rate of recovery from injury? Imagine the advantage if you can prove something like that in space. It has a huge potential for application on Earth itself, helping people with muscle degeneration, or degenerative diseases.

Q. Did you conduct some experiments on nutrition too?
Yes, we conducted experiments that looked at nutrition for long-duration space missions. How do you pack more and more nutrition in less and less space? Essentially, you come up with solutions in that constrained environment, which in turn can help solve problems of food security on Earth. It is not a one-way street—some of the science being done has immediate application on Earth and some has potential in a longer duration.



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Q. Did you speak to your wife when you were up there?
Yeah, I did speak to her. You can place a call, depending on satellite coverage. It was mostly audio, as video calls need to be organised. We had two or three chances to speak to family and friends in these entire 20 days. Initially, when I went up in space, we were totally cut off. So, I had no idea what was